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Theologiae Cursus Integer ad Mentem Scoti — Disputatio XXVIII, Quaestio I (*The Complete Course of Theology according to the Mind of Scotus*)

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DISPUTATION XXVIII.

On those things which are prerequired for the act of faith.

After the nature of faith has been declared, it is fitting that it be shown what things are necessary in order that someone may elicit an act of it. I speak, moreover, of those things which are particularly required for this: for of the necessity of grace, which is not more required for the act of faith than for other supernatural acts, and of the use of reason, without which no moral act can be elicited, no particular mention is to be made here. Therefore, two things principally are to be treated in this disputation. *First*, of the proposal of the mysteries to be believed; *Second*, of the will, or volition, of believing, which is commonly called among Theologians the pious affection of credulity.

QUESTION I.

Who has the authority of proposing the things of faith.

It is certain that anyone whosoever, who by whatever means knows the mysteries of faith, whether he believes them or not, can propose them, saying that they are revealed by God; and that even that proposal can suffice, so that he who has the habit of faith may be able to elicit an act of faith, if the other aids are present.

It would also be possible for whoever knows the motives of credibility of the mysteries of our faith to propose them to anyone whomsoever, and, by their mediation, to persuade him that they are revealed by God; whence he could cooperate very greatly, so that some infidel or heretic might be converted to the faith, and, thus converted, might most firmly elicit acts of faith.

It is asked, therefore, concerning such authority, by reason of which someone would be bound to believe the one having it, when he proposes the things of faith.

CONCLUSION I.

2. {marg. Bishops, Parish Priests, Preachers, and Professors of Theology have the authority of proposing the things of faith.} *Bishops, Parish Priests, Preachers, and Masters and Professors of Sacred Theology have authority of this kind, respectively, with regard to their subjects, and all those who come to them for the sake of instruction, whenever there occurs no reasonable cause of doubting their capacity or sincerity. It is proved:* because, if they were not believed in a matter so grave, and one in which, if they did not speak the truth, they would sin mortally, a notable injury would be done to them; because their honesty would be doubted without sufficient cause.

Further, he who, ignorant of the mysteries of faith, would not believe them, would expose himself to the manifest danger of falling into great errors against the faith, and of not believing some things which would necessarily have to be believed.

I said in the conclusion, *when there would be no reasonable cause of doubting*; because that would without doubt excuse from this obligation. Now there would be a reasonable cause when it were known that others, to whom greater or equal credence ought to be given, held the contrary; or when it were known that they rather often lied in a proposal of this kind; or when they said that they gathered the mystery proposed to be *de fide* by their own discourse, and the goodness of the discourse were doubted; or when they were known to be unlearned, and could not know the thing proposed to be *de fide* without learning.

CONCLUSION II.

3. {marg. In these matters there is not required an authority infallible, even morally.} *There is not required an authority infallible, even morally, in matters of this kind, in order that someone either believe or be bound to believe.* This seems the common view, against Coninck, disp.5.de fide s.1. It is evident, because they could morally err in this, and lie; and it can be known that they could morally err and lie, even at the very time when someone believes them; because there are no principles by which any of these things is impeded. Whence also, when someone believes, and is bound to believe on account of the reasons of the preceding conclusion, he can still have a speculative doubt about the truth of the thing which he believes.

You will object on behalf of Coninck: The things which are believed by divine faith ought to be believed certainly and without doubt; but they cannot be so believed in dependence upon a proposal which is known not to be, at least morally, infallible; therefore the proposal must be known as such, in order that someone may believe, or be bound to believe, by divine faith.

It is confirmed: because otherwise heretical doctrine could be proposed with an obligation that someone believe it just as well as Catholic doctrine. *I respond* that not all things which are believed by divine faith must be so believed, if we speak of speculative certitude, holding itself on the part of the intellect; but if that be true of the certitude of adhesion on the part of the will, it does not bear upon the point at issue, because the minor of the argument would be false. As is evident in the heretics, who thus believe things false and badly proposed. Nor do I believe that every act of faith must have such certitude of adhesion, but only those which are proposed in a morally infallible manner. *To the confirmation* I respond by conceding the consequence, speaking of a proposal which is made only by a particular person, and which is not known to be common to the Church, except through her authority.

CONCLUSION III.

4. {marg. Some infallible rule is necessary, by which the mysteries of faith may be known to be revealed.} *Some infallible rule of proposing those things which are revealed by God as necessarily to be believed is necessary, to which all must conform themselves, when it is proposed to them.* This is common.

It is proved: because without such a rule sufficient knowledge of the mysteries of faith necessary for salvation could easily fail, since someone, for example, could deny that Confession is necessary for salvation, another assert it; and gradually, with the passage of time, it could happen that, several Doctors agreeing in this, the erroneous side would be rendered more probable — which most of all has place in the mysteries for the knowing of which no human reason suffices, but whose truth totally depends upon divine revelation, made by God of old. *It is confirmed:* because, from the fact that all do not in fact agree upon this rule, various heresies have arisen, and still continue; therefore many more would arise and be propagated, if God had not provided a rule of this kind.

CONCLUSION IV.

5. {marg. Sacred Scripture is such a rule.} *Sacred Scripture is a rule of this kind.* This is common to Catholics and to heretics.

It is proved: because it is the written word of God; but the word of God, who can neither be deceived nor deceive, is without doubt such a rule. The major *is proved:* because it is received as such by so great a multitude of men of diverse condition throughout the whole world, who, it is morally evident, would not have received it as such unless it were proposed to them as such by motives at least morally evident. *It is confirmed* through the motives of credibility of our faith, which prove this just as much as anything else. I do not adduce the definition of Trident. on this matter, ses.4., because it is not more established that Trent has authority to define this than this very conclusion itself; whence to prove the latter through Trent would be to prove the unknown through the equally unknown. Nevertheless, that proof is valid for Catholics who would believe the authority of the Council, and yet would doubt of this, if any such were to be found.

CONCLUSION V.

6. {marg. Scripture itself does not suffice for a rule.} *Scripture itself does not suffice for an infallible rule for knowing the mysteries of faith — even those very ones which are truly contained in Scripture — in such wise that, notwithstanding it, one could not reasonably doubt of many things, unless he had another rule.* This is most common among all Catholics against the heretics.

It is proved: because without another rule it would not be established that Scripture itself is the word of God, nor, consequently, that it is such a rule.

It is confirmed: because among the Fathers of old, and men most holy and most learned, there was doubt concerning various parts of Scripture; nor could they gather from Scripture whether or not they were the word of God; but they had to have recourse to another rule, which, if it were not infallible, at least morally, it would still be uncertain whether they were the word of God.

It is proved secondly: because there are many mysteries of faith which are not contained expressly in Scripture, nor could they be deduced from it infallibly by any consequence, as is evident from the mystery of the Eucharist in that manner in which it is held by the Catholic Church, from the secret confession of sins, from the per se infused virtues, etc.; therefore Scripture does not suffice for them. But that these are mysteries of faith is as evidently plain as it is plain that Scripture itself exists; whence the heretics most inconsequently deny them, while they concede Scripture.

It is proved thirdly: because Scripture itself has many parts that are very difficult, and which admit of various interpretations and senses; whence it arises that it is very difficult to know its proper sense, which the Holy Spirit had intended; but in order that it might be, by itself alone, a sufficient rule, it ought not to be so difficult, nor so liable to various interpretations.

And hence it also arises that those who rely upon Scripture alone go off into as many senses as they have heads, and fight among themselves in a wondrous manner — which was very nearly the cause of all the heresies that have arisen in the Church of God; therefore Scripture alone does not suffice for settling the controversies of faith, nor for proposing the mysteries necessary for salvation.

The heretics say that Scripture is not obscure in proposing the things necessary for salvation; but it is evident from what has been said that this is false; and besides, it is shown thus: because, if it were so, the heretics themselves, who profess that they rely totally upon it, would not have so many contentions among themselves, but would agree, at least in all those things necessary for salvation — which, however, they themselves must confess to be manifestly false.

CONCLUSION VI.

7. {marg. The private spirit is not a sufficient rule of faith.} *The private spirit, by which each one would be interiorly illuminated by God for knowing the mysteries of faith, is not that infallible rule which is required, and which suffices, for knowing what things are mysteries of faith.* This is common to Catholics against the Calvinists.

It is proved: both because it is established neither by reason nor by authority that such a spirit is given; and because it could not be proved whose spirit would be true and whose false; nor could it be shown how the one could be discerned from the other; but that would be necessary in order for it to be a rule of this kind.

An egregious circle the heretics commit when they are pressed by this difficulty: for they prove the truth of the spirit through Scripture, and Scripture itself, and its true sense, they prove through this private spirit — which is so ridiculous that it is a wonder it could come into the mind of anyone in possession of his reason. Moreover, the authorities of Scripture by which they prove that a spirit of this kind is given must first of all suppose that Scripture is true, and that that sense in which they themselves understand it is its true sense; therefore, for knowing both, they must have another rule than that spirit.

Further, in truth those authorities intend nothing less than such a spirit: for they treat only of the spirit of grace and of intrinsic aid, which God gives to whom He wills, for working well, and also for understanding Scripture, even in a good sense; yet not in such a way that from this they could reasonably convert any others to the true faith, or that it could suffice for themselves as a reasonable rule, when others would contend with them and propose good reasons for doubting the truth of that sense, and most of all when that sense would be against the sense of the Church, as seems manifest. Except when God would evidently reveal that sense to them interiorly — which certainly not even God Himself can do, when the sense is contrary to the sense which the Church proposes as *de fide*; because otherwise He would lie, either then, or when He dictated that contrary sense which the Church, as she received it from Him, had dictated before.

CONCLUSION VII.

8. {marg. Tradition is an infallible rule of faith.} *Some tradition, not written in those books which are in fact held for Sacred Scripture, is an infallible rule of faith, in such wise that each one must hold for an article of faith whatever is proposed as such through such tradition.*

This is common to Catholics against the heretics. Now by tradition is here understood some doctrine, not contained expressly in Scripture, or not believed from the fact that it is thus contained in Scripture — although it would truly be contained in it, if its true sense were understood — handed down from hand to hand, as is said, or from one age to another, from Christ and the Apostles, and always held commonly by the Church as revealed by God: as is, for example, that very doctrine concerning the four Gospels of Matt. Mark, Luke, John, which has always been held as revealed by God — that is, that God has revealed that those four Gospels are His own written words, or that whatever is written in them is true in His true sense.

It is proved: because it is as established that tradition of this kind is from God as that Scripture itself is; and the motives of credibility convince us that it is infallible just as much as Scripture itself, or any other mystery of faith whatsoever; and without it, it would not be infallibly established that Scripture itself is infallible; nor would its true sense become known concerning many mysteries of faith that must necessarily be believed. Nor would the whole Church ever have accepted it so universally, with such great continuation, as revealed by God, unless she had moral evidence that it was so.

It is confirmed: because the Council of Constantinop. Act. 7. gives force of this kind to traditions of this kind; the Seventh Synod, which is the second Nicene, Act. 1.; and most recently Trident. ses.4.; Basil de Spiritu sancto, cap.7.; Iren. lib.3. cap. 3.; August. epist.3. & 86. — which confirmation I add both on account of Catholics, who give credence to Councils and Fathers, and on account of heretics and infidels — not that they grant great authority to Councils or Fathers, but that it may appear that such was the sense of the Church commonly in every age; which indeed must be morally established as certain just as much as those things are morally established for us which historians of good repute write, without any doubt or controversy.

It is confirmed secondly from Scripture itself, to which the heretics attribute so much, that even from it too they may be convicted. 2.Thessalon.2. Hold the traditions which you have learned, whether by word, or by our Epistle; 1. Timoth. vltimo: Keep that which is committed to thy trust. Where by the deposit the Fathers understand the doctrine committed to him, according to the exposition of Paul himself, 2. Tim. 1. Hold the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me in faith, and in love: keep the good thing committed to thy trust.

9. You will object first: It would follow that Scripture is incomplete, if it did not contain sufficiently expressly and clearly all necessary things; but this seems absurd.

I respond by distinguishing the major: as to this, that it would not contain all those things in that manner, I concede it, nor is this absurd, because God so willed; for just as Christ Himself did not propose His doctrine by Himself in any scripture of His own, nor did He even deliver all the things He said so clearly but that it is difficult to understand many things He said — for an end without doubt good — so it was not necessary that Scripture should contain all things, or so clearly as the heretics would have it, for the same end, or any other good end whatsoever, which God had intended. As to this, that it would not contain all necessary things, and with that same clarity with which it seemed to God expedient for the end intended by Him, I deny the major.

And so it is certain that no scripture or doctrine ought to seem incomplete when it contains all things, and in that same manner, which is expedient for the end intended by its author, even though it did not contain all necessary things, or in the same manner which would conduce to other ends. Certainly the things which Christ had said parabolically and rather obscurely, He could have said without enigmas or parables, and far more clearly, if He had wished; and the whole of Scripture could have been proposed by God more clearly than it has in fact been proposed, and that would have been far better in order to this, that it might be more easily understood, and that the various heresies arisen about its sense might be avoided; and yet He did not do so, because it was not expedient that He should do so, in order to other ends intended by Him.

You will object secondly: Scripture forbids anything to be added to it, Deuteronom. 4. & Apocalyps. vltimo.

I respond to this frivolous objection — one which it is a wonder that any man of any judgment should propose: that Scripture means only that nothing be added to it which is contrary to its sense, or as a part of it; but not that nothing more be held for a thing revealed by God than is contained in that scripture in which this is proposed. And that it does not mean anything else is manifest; because it is certain, and admitted by the heretics themselves, that many other things were added to Scripture after Deuteronomy; and it is certain that St. John meant only that nothing was to be added to his own Apocalypse itself, as a part of the Apocalypse itself. But it is most evident that this is not to the point, nor does it impede the force of traditions.

Similar is the third objection, from Isaïæ 29. Matth.15. Galat.1. 1.Petr.2., where the traditions of men are reproved.

I respond that this is to be understood of the traditions of men not having God for their author. But neither is it to be understood of all similar traditions of men, but of those which would be against divine or natural law, or which would be preferred to the divine or natural law: for what would be more absurd than that this should be thought to be understood of a tradition which might exist in some Commonwealth, that the first-born son should succeed to the inheritance of his father, or of other similar things not evil of themselves?

You will object fourthly that traditions are subject to the defects of uncertainty and of oblivion, and consequently that they cannot oblige.

It is responded by denying the consequence: because, at least before they fall into oblivion, and before it is morally uncertain whether they are true, they will oblige.

I respond secondly that the traditions of things necessarily to be believed are not morally uncertain, nor can they be consigned to oblivion in the universal Church; because it is impossible, morally speaking, that among the greater part of the Church care should not be had of preserving them; just as it is impossible, morally speaking, that in the Church, universally speaking, the perpetual memory of the Apostles' Creed should not be preserved.

It is confirmed: because in the same way Scripture could be subject to uncertainty and oblivion, even as to its true sense: for if we speak of the autograph Scripture, written by the Apostles themselves, that certainly cannot reach all the nations — as many as believe, and must believe under peril of losing eternal salvation, on account of the want of the things necessarily to be believed which are contained in

it — nor can it be understood by all of them in that language in which it was written; whence it necessarily had to be translated by some, and they could easily err in the interpretation, unless they had the particular assistance of the Holy Spirit — which assistance the antecedent Scripture certainly did not testify that they had, and consequently it would have to be proved from elsewhere. And even if all understood another language, still, since the same autographs could not reach all, it would without doubt have to be transcribed; but in that transcription, so manifold, which would have to be made — good God! how many errors, whether of letters, or of points, or of commas, which could totally invert the sense, would easily creep in — so that truly anyone, even of middling intelligence, could deservedly doubt whether they were correctly transcribed, even as to the necessary part, if he did not have another rule to which he ought to conform himself. Of which matter more could be said, if brevity were not to be attended to, and if it were not my purpose, should God grant life and grace, to treat more fully of the controversies of faith on another occasion.

CONCLUSION VIII.

10. {marg. Particular Councils are not an infallible rule of proposing the mysteries of faith.} *Particular Councils are not an infallible rule of proposing the mysteries of faith, or divine revelations.* This is common among Catholics, and much more among the heretics, who deny that authority to general Councils, to which it is evident that it ought rather to be attributed.

Now I understand by particular Councils not only episcopal ones, where the Clergy of one Episcopate is gathered, with the Bishop presiding; nor only provincial ones, where all the clerics of one Archiepiscopal Province are convoked, with the Archbishop of the same Province presiding; but also national ones (as they are called), consisting of the congregation of all the Archbishops and Bishops and Clergy of one entire nation — for example, the Irish, the Spanish, or the French — under whatever president to whom that would belong by right or by election.

It is proved first: because Councils of this kind erred in the time of St. Cyprian, and that they can err is handed down in the Roman Council under Symmachus — which proof I do not adduce here to prove the matter from authority in any other way than insofar as from it it is established that that was then the more common sense of the Church, which sense without doubt is to be preferred to the sense of Councils of this kind, or to their determinations.

It is proved secondly — and more to my purpose, who proceed here by reasons, as one ought, unless I am mistaken, to proceed in this matter, in which the infallible rule of faith must be proved, not supposed: because such Councils do not represent the whole Church; nor is it established, either by an authority which ought here to be believed, or by reason, that such authority belongs to them; but unless that be established, it will always be uncertain, even morally, concerning the truth of the things proposed by them, even as *de fide*.

Hence, however, it does not follow but that subjects, and whoever else understand the determination of Councils of this kind as to the things of faith, ought to defer much authority to them, and even to believe under pain of sin, unless a reason for doubting be established for them from elsewhere; nor will it suffice — as I now teach — that they do not have the infallible assistance of the Holy Spirit, but they must have another reason. Now it will suffice for learned men that they know that the motives by which they are led to define it are not sufficient; but much more, if they know that that matter is not so held by other nations, and is new. For the simpler folk, however, I judge that no reason will suffice, unless the thing determined were contrary to those things which they have always had proposed to them as things of faith; for then they could deservedly doubt, and even, most prudently, not believe, except after consulting others; and especially if they heard that those determinations were contradicted by Councils of similar quality, and much more by the Roman Pontiff; but it would be necessary that they hear that with some moral evidence of its truth; because, if some two or three, even learned and pious men, said it, it ought not to suffice; because that Council is rather to be believed than they.

But even the more learned themselves, who might know that the motives of Councils of this kind for determining such things are not sufficient, ought to beware lest, publicly or privately, they signify to others that those determinations are not to be believed, before they could confirm this by better authority or reason; but they ought first to inform the supreme Pontiff; and if the matter were such that from belief in it some danger could threaten the salvation of others, it would be more advisable that they propose that danger to others, and on that account, as far as they could, cautiously and secretly turn them away from giving credence to those determinations.

11. *In truth*, moreover, it scarcely appears morally probable that anything immediately necessary for salvation — and invincible ignorance of which would not free anyone from danger to salvation — could be determined in such Councils;

because those things which are in such manner necessary for salvation are so sufficiently proposed that it seems morally impossible that the opposite should be determined by such Councils in such a way but that to the simpler folk themselves there would occur a reason for doubting, deservedly sufficient — namely, from the fact that it is against that which was proposed to them before, without any controversy, as necessary for salvation.

All this I confirm by an example: For when Henry VIII., King of England, was falling away from the Church, if he had then so prevailed with the Prelates of all England that they agreed with him (which could very well happen, on account of the assistance promised to them by the Holy Spirit not being necessary), so as to declare that the supreme Pontiff is not the true head of the Church on earth and the Vicar of Christ, and that auricular confession is not necessary for salvation, nor the Saints to be invoked — assuredly any particular Catholic of that kingdom could, and ought to, withhold credence from that determination, because it was directly against the doctrine which they had before received commonly from those very Prelates; and much more could any learned man persuade them of this, and even expose his own life for it, if it were necessary, as many did. But if something else were determined by them concerning the understanding of some passage of Scripture, which was not against the doctrine received by them before as of faith, even if in point of fact it were false, the simpler folk ought to believe it, until they sufficiently understood that the contrary was taught by the universal Church or by the Pontiff; and the more learned ought to proceed with the aforesaid caution — all of which seems to me, from the very terms, sufficiently apparent.

CONCLUSION IX.

12. {marg. The authority of a general Council is such a rule.} *The authority of a general and universal Council, legitimately congregated in the name of the whole Church, and approved, is an infallible rule of faith, as to those things which it proposes as de fide to be believed.* This is common to all Catholics against the heretics.

It is proved: because from Apostolic tradition it is established that Councils of this kind have such authority, and cannot propose as revealed things any but such as are so; whence from the very beginning of the Church down to these times recourse was had to them in the graver difficulties, and the congregated Councils

themselves always judged that they had such authority — which certainly could not happen unless it were established for them through a tradition sufficiently manifested.

It is confirmed: if what was decreed by Councils of this kind were not infallibly de fide, the Pontiff could err in proposing the things of faith, as Pontiff; because, in order that the determinations of these Councils be de fide, he would have to approve them, and, so approving, he would propose to be de fide what is not de fide; but, as I shall say presently, he cannot err in this.

It is confirmed secondly: because the authority of Councils of this kind is not denied except by men or congregations of a thousand times less authority; therefore it would be most imprudent, on account of the authority of such, to deny the authority of Councils of this kind — especially since it cannot be shown that any one of so many of this kind as there have been from the time of Christ has ever failed in proposing the things of faith, as is evident from the easy solution of certain instances which the heretics propose, to be seen in Bellarmine — in whom also may be seen what is required for a Council of this kind, who could convoke it, who preside in it, whether it must be confirmed by the Pope, whether it is above the Pope, and other matters which have no speculative difficulty, but only a historical or Theological one of easy dispatch.

CONCLUSION X.

13. The Roman Pontiff, who is the Supreme Pontiff of the whole Church, has authority of this kind even outside a Council.

This is most common among Catholics, and it is proved: because it is established from the continual tradition of the Church, always attributing to him authority of this kind — which it is not likely she would do unless that tradition were Apostolic; nor is it likely that the Pontiffs themselves, very many of whom were most holy and most learned, would assume that authority to themselves, unless it were so. The authorities of the Fathers and Councils by which that tradition is established, and the common sense of the Church on this matter, are to be seen in Bellarmine, lib.3.de Pontifice, and other controversialists, who easily solve the objections of the heretics, of which it pleases me to propose only two here.

You will object first: If the Pontiff had authority of this kind, general Councils would be congregated in vain for defining the things of faith, with so many expenses and difficulties.

I respond by denying the consequence. *First*, because the Pontiff is not wont to define certain difficulties, nor any without a previous diligent examination; but none more opportune can be made than that which is made when Councils of this kind are congregated; whence for this they are most usefully congregated.

Further, through the consent of so many Prelates, Schism would be more easily obviated, and the oppositions of heretics against the decisions made in a Council would be met.

It is objected secondly: In order that what was proposed by the Pope should be of infallible authority, it would have to be believed that he himself is the true Pope; and thus it would be de fide that Innocent X., who reigns today, was canonically and truly elected; but this is not true, because it is not established that God ever revealed it; and because some Theologians think that one could be elected Pope, and held for such, who was not truly such.

I respond first by denying the consequence of the major: because the moral certitude which would be had that he is the true Pope suffices for this, that someone may believe by divine faith the things proposed by him; and certainly I judge it sufficiently probable that the Apostolic tradition which is had concerning the infallible authority of the Pope extends itself to all Popes who are known with moral evidence to be such, whether they be believed by divine faith to be such or not, and also whether they truly be such or not — provided it could happen that someone should be held for Pope with such certitude who was not truly Pope.

14. {marg. He who is commonly held for Pope without sufficient reason for doubting is to be believed de fide to be the true Pope.} *I respond secondly* by denying the minor: for truly I judge it to be an article of faith that whoever is commonly held by the Church as canonically and legitimately elected, without reasonable cause of doubting, is the true Pope — especially after he should actually exercise his authority as to deciding some controversies of faith, or the convocation of a general Council.

This is proved: because it is de fide that God gave to Peter and to his successors infallible authority of this kind; but if it were not believed in particular that to this and to that successor such authority has been granted, and that this one and that

one is his true successor, it would serve for nothing, and such authority would be communicated in vain to the successors of Peter, because it could always be doubted who was his true successor; therefore this must be believed.

It is proved secondly: because it does not suffice to believe in universal that the Church founded by God is of infallible truth, and incapable of professing error in matter of faith; but it is required to believe in particular that some determinate Church is such: for to what would that faith rendered in universal serve? Therefore it does not suffice to believe in general that the legitimate successors of Peter are of infallible authority; but it is required to believe in particular that this successor of his has such authority, and consequently is his true successor — at least at some time; but never rather than in the case of the conclusion: and truly, otherwise that faith would be altogether useless, and uselessly would it be revealed by God, or such authority communicated to his successors.

It is proved thirdly: Because from time to time, from the beginning of the Church until now, as is established from the Ecclesiastical Histories, the faithful believed that those who were held, without reason for doubting, for Pontiffs, were truly such — in which there certainly would not be such general agreement, unless there were an Apostolic tradition on that matter. And so without doubt Christ revealed this truth to the Apostles, and they to others; whence it is established that the first proof of the minor is false; and as to the second part, I say that those Theologians were deceived.

I said in this response, *without reasonable cause of doubting;* because in such a case there would be no obligation of believing that he, of whom there was doubt, is the true Pope. Now the case in which there could be such a doubt could occur when the Princes of the Church, with whom the election lay, not only did not agree in the election of one man, but some part of them elected one, and another part another, as has sometimes happened; or when manifest force were applied to them, by which they were compelled to elect one whom they would not otherwise wish to elect.

I said also, especially when he should actually exercise his authority, deciding something de fide, in order to abstract from the difficulties of certain cases admitted by some Theologians — as that a woman, or one not baptized, might be elected and held for Pope without any reason for doubting, although nevertheless they would not be capable of the Papacy, and consequently would not truly be Popes. For although these cases would be possible, not only absolutely, but even as

the Church is subject to the particular providence of God concerning her, nevertheless I altogether judge that God would never permit that they should proceed to the decision of any doctrine of faith.

In truth, however, I judge it must be said that it pertains to the particular providence of God concerning His Church — which He has placed upon a firm rock, and against which the gates of hell shall never prevail — that He never permit such elections, or others invalid, to take place, but that immediately, in the very beginning, reasonable reasons for doubting appear, on account of which the election ought to be held as suspect, or as manifestly invalid: for just as it would pertain to that providence to prevent such persons — who would not be true Popes, but would be held for such without any reason for doubting — from proceeding to the decision of things of faith, as the authors holding that those cases can in fact occur confess: so it would be much more sweet, more congruous, and equally easy to prevent their being elected in such a manner that there would be no doubt of his true election.

15. *You will ask*, however, concerning this: whether it follows, from the fact that it is de fide that a Pope of whose true election there is no doubt is the true Pope, that his election is legitimate.

I respond that the legitimate election of a Pope can be considered in two ways. *First*, in such wise that it be such that, by its mediation, the true Papacy is truly conferred upon the person elected — whether the election itself be sinful and invalid, and whether the true Papacy was conferred by virtue of it alone, or by its mediation through God supplying its defect — and in this sense it manifestly follows that the election must be legitimate; because otherwise the one elected would not be the true Pope.

Second, in such wise that the election itself not be of itself sinful, by reason of the sins which are wont to invalidate elections, as by reason of simony or coercion.

But in this sense I judge that it does not follow that the election is good; because, although he would not as yet be Pope, he would be the true Pope when such defects were not publicly established, and when some principal party did not, by reason of them, immediately oppose itself to the election; because since — unless those defects were publicly established, or opposition were made to the election on account of them — the man so elected would be held for Pope without rational reason for doubting, it must altogether be said that these defects do not impede the

validity of the election, although they would impede the validity of other elections, and of this one also, if they became publicly known, and opposition were therefore immediately made to it.

You say that those defects can even then render the election, according to itself, invalid; for although he who by its mediation became Pope would be truly such, this would not follow by force of the election, but it would have to be ascribed to God Himself, supplying the defect of the election.

Against this: because this is to reduce the difficulty to a question about a name: for by a valid election we understand that election which, being posited, the one elected is truly Pope; but such would that election be, no less than if it did not have those defects.

It could, nevertheless, be said with sufficient probability — what I taught in my Commentary — that the election will always be without these defects when the contrary is not publicly established, and no opposition is made on that account; because this seems to pertain to the particular providence of God: and even if some actions of the electors should seem to argue some such defects, nevertheless, when the election itself was to be made, and was made peacefully, and without tumult, it is more likely that those defects would be removed through retractation, or penance, or some other way.

16. {marg. Whether the Pope can institute a new article of faith.} *You will ask secondly:* Whether the Pope, or a general Council, can institute some new article of faith.

It is certain that, if by a new article of faith were understood some proposition which before the determination of the Pope was not held for an article of faith, and afterwards would be, they can institute a new article of faith, and have often instituted such in this sense: and certainly otherwise the infallible authority granted to him by God for determining the controversies of faith would serve for nothing. But it is not of this kind that we treat here, but whether the Pope or a Council can declare or propose something to be believed as *de fide* on account of some new revelation which might be made to them — something which neither in general nor in particular was revealed before by Christ to the Apostles or to others, whether obscurely or clearly.

But the common and true opinion of Theologians is that they cannot; because from the practice and usage of the Pontiffs and Councils it is had that they have never attempted to do this; because they have never proposed anything relying upon such a new revelation; nor, when there was doubt about certain truths of faith, did they use any diligence, not even of prayers or of good works, to obtain from God a revelation of this kind; and although it is likely that of the holy Pontiffs many had particular revelations, nevertheless they never proposed them to be believed by the faithful as propositions of divine faith, but always used the diligence of searching the Scriptures, and of investigating the traditions of the Church, concerning the matter to be decided as *de fide* — which is a most evident sign that neither they nor the Church ever judged that such authority resided with them.

17. *You will say first:* The Pontiffs and Councils have often determined that certain passages of Scripture have this or that sense, and do not have that sense in which the heretics abused them; but after that definition, that was *de fide*, before it was not; nor yet was there of old a revelation that that was its sense: therefore the Pontiffs and Councils either had a new revelation on that matter, or proposed something to be believed as *de fide* which was not *de fide*: for nothing can be *de fide* which was not revealed at some time.

This is confirmed: because the very proposal of the Pontiffs and Councils concerning such a sense is a new revelation: for since God has promised them His assistance in the proposals of the things of faith, it evidently follows that He assisted them while they were proposing such a sense; whence that proposal is a revelation of God, just as well as if He signified His mind in any other manner whatsoever.

I respond that this objection does not seem to me to the point of the difficulty; because the question is not about the sense of Scripture, but about other things which are not contained in Scripture, nor established from tradition; but that sense is contained in Scripture, and is gathered from Scripture itself, or from tradition, to be the true sense of that passage; and therefore it is determined to be such by the Pontiff or Council.

Whence I respond directly by denying the minor: because that sense either is revealed in Scripture, insofar as it can be gathered from Scripture that it is its true sense, or it was revealed to the Apostles, and by them to the Church through tradition.

To the confirmation I respond that that proposal of the Pontiff and of Councils is a new revelation of God, but one dependent upon His ancient revelation, both concerning that sense of Scripture, and concerning the promise which He had made of assisting in such proposals of the Church; whence it is not to the point.

You will say secondly: The Pontiff, when he canonizes Saints, proposes that they are in heaven, as a thing to be believed *de fide*; but God did not reveal of old that St. Francis would be in heaven, or that he would die in such a state, from which it would follow that he would be in heaven after death: therefore.

I respond first that it is sufficiently probable that it is not proposed as to be believed *de fide* that canonized Saints are in heaven, but as something morally certain, by Theological knowledge, relying upon this Theological principle certain as *de fide*: That whoever has lived well, and has done penance corresponding to his imperfections, if he has committed any, is to be endowed with beatitude immediately after death; and upon this natural proposition, morally certain, that St. Francis so lived, and did such penance — the certitude of which proposition depends upon those motives by which the Church was moved to gather this, after such exact diligence as she is wont to employ in this matter; which truly is very great, and sufficient to persuade of it morally anyone well disposed who knows and considers it.

Nor does it matter that in the Bull of canonization the Pontiff is wont to command the faithful not to doubt of the existence of the canonized in heaven; for he could command this, although he did not think it to be *de fide*, from this alone, that it is morally certain, and that doubt about it could redound to the detriment of the faithful. But neither does he forbid speculative doubt, which could be compatible with faith itself, and which is not dependent upon the will of the faithful, except insofar as it is in their power to reject it as far as they can, just as they ought to put away evil thoughts. But he does forbid the quasi-practical doubt, from which it would follow that they would wish, on account of that doubt, to omit praying to those Saints, and venerating them; for this is the doubt which would harm them.

I respond secondly that it is also sufficiently probable that it is *de fide* that the canonized are in heaven; but I deny, nevertheless, that it thence follows that a new article of faith can be instituted in the sense controverted here; because that truth depends upon an ancient revelation, likely made to the Apostles, that whoever should be canonized by the Pope would without doubt be in heaven; or upon that other, that He would assist the Pontiff, lest he propose something as *de fide* which

was not de fide; and truly I judge this to be by far the more probable; because, since it could be de fide in this way, and since the common estimation of the Church is that it so happens, it seems by far more probable that it is so.